Centre for the New Economy and Society

WORLD ECONOMIC FORUM

Chief People Officers' Outlook

INSIGHT REPORT

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May 2026

Chief People Officers' Outlook

The World Economic Forum's Chief People Officers' Outlook provides a regular appraisal on global labour market sentiment, emerging workforce strategy trends and organizational talent priorities. Developed in collaboration with the Forum's community of chief people officers, the briefing builds on a targeted survey, consultations with people leaders, expert insights and the latest global workforce strategy research.

The Forum's community of chief people officers convenes more than 140 people leaders from large global employers, representing a broad cross-section of the global economy. Regionally, members are roughly equally split between North America and Europe, with growing representation from Latin America, the Middle East, Africa and Asia. The community includes diversified representation from many sectors, including professional services, banking, insurance and asset management, information technology, healthcare, energy, agriculture, food and beverage, consumer, entertainment, and infrastructure industries.

The survey featured in this briefing was distributed to members of the World Economic Forum's community of chief people officers and was conducted between 15 January and 2 March 2026.

Executive summary

This May 2026 edition of the Chief People Officers' Outlook examines how geoeconomic and geopolitical tensions, economic volatility and technology trends are perceived to be reshaping global talent dynamics, workforce strategy and organizational priorities in the year ahead.

Chief people officers perceive a divided short-term outlook for global labour markets. While 50% expect talent availability to improve over the next 12 months, 30% anticipate weaker conditions, and 20% foresee no change. Expectations for job creation are similarly mixed, reflecting ongoing uncertainty and diverging regional and industrial dynamics. The most acute challenge cited is not overall talent supply, but talent matching and access to critical skills.

Workforce strategy priorities remain consistent with those found in the outlook's September 2025 edition. Reviewing organizational structure and job design has emerged as the top priority for the coming months (74% of respondents), followed by expanding upskilling and reskilling programmes and supporting workforce deployment of artificial intelligence (AI) and automation (each cited by 70%).

AI adoption in the workforce is increasingly perceived to be moving from exploration to implementation. Around 83% of chief people officers expect their organizations to be in the scaling phase of AI deployment within the next 6–12 months, integrating AI tools across functions and processes. As adoption advances, attention is shifting from individual upskilling towards redesigning roles, workflows and talent systems to ensure sustainable workforce outcomes.

Geopolitical fragmentation and geoeconomic volatility are emerging as significant forces shaping workforce strategy. Geopolitics and geoeconomics are no longer confined to trade, technology and capital flows; they are directly impacting access to skills and workforce planning. Government labour market interventions, migration and visa restrictions, and cyberthreats are among the most-cited disruptors. Their tangible impacts include constrained access to international talent, wage pressures and shifting regional demand. In response, organizations are strengthening internal mobility and redeployment, enhancing cybersecurity and developing diversified regional talent hubs. Yet, while firm-level adaptation is accelerating, chief people officers emphasize that durable workforce resilience will depend on stronger system-level coordination, including cross-border talent mobility, stronger education, skills and workforce ecosystems, and deeper public-private collaboration to build more resilient global labour markets.

Introduction

This May 2026 edition of the Chief People Officers' Outlook examines how rising geopolitical tensions and geoeconomic volatility are impacting workforce strategy. Geopolitical volatility is increasingly viewed not as episodic disruption, but as a structural feature of the operating environment shaping workforce planning and organizational design.[1] How are organizations planning to strengthen workforce readiness and resilience as global value chains shift, structural pressures intensify and regulatory environments continue to diverge?

The outlook begins with a appraisal on global and regional labour market sentiment, capturing the present attitude shaping decision-making. It then examines current workforce strategy trends, with a particular focus on artificial intelligence (AI) deployment as a major cross-cutting theme impacting the workplace. Finally, this edition explores the workforce impact of increased geopolitical and geoeconomic fragmentation, moving from the current labour market landscape to organizational responses and system-level implications, underscoring the interconnectedness of today's challenges and the need for coordinated strategies across organizations, stakeholders and borders.

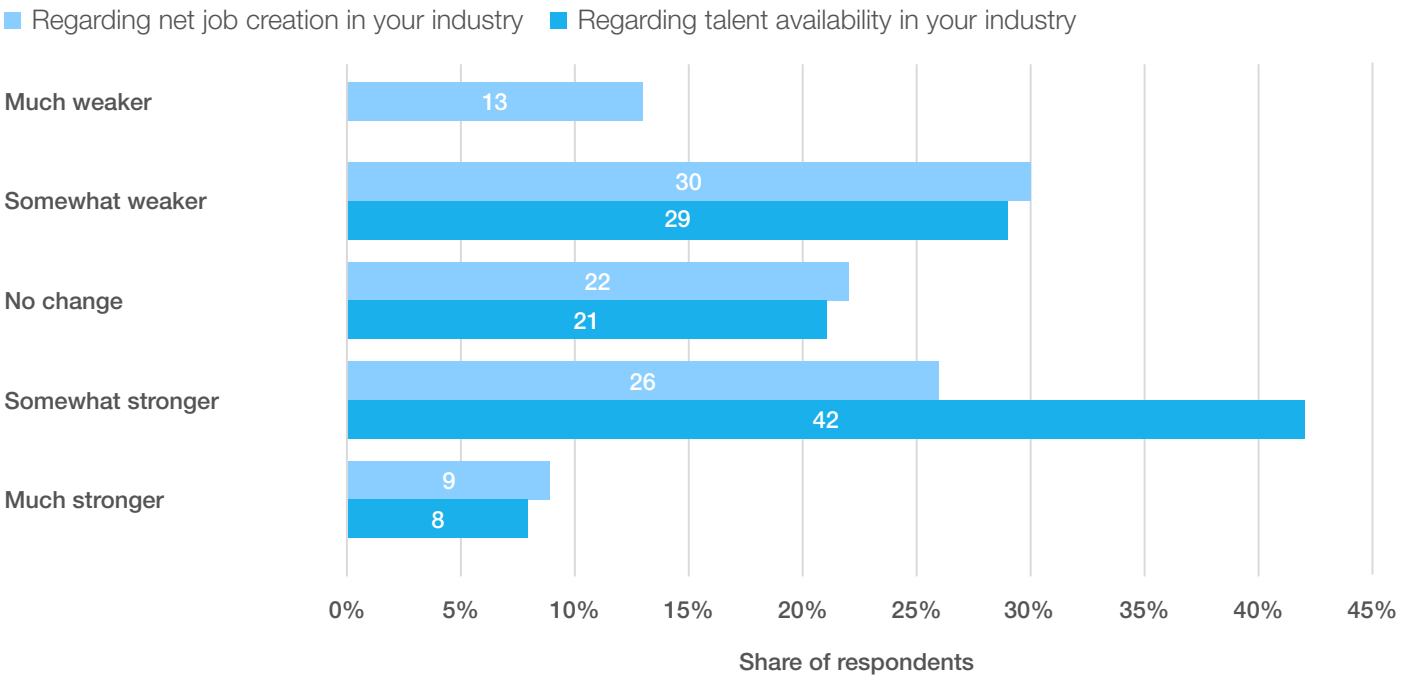
The survey featured in this briefing was conducted between 15 January and 2 March 2026.

1 Talent and labour market trends

Global 12-month talent trends

The Chief People Officers' Outlook tracks shifts in sentiment on global labour market conditions by regularly surveying short-term expectations around talent availability and job creation.

Figure 1
Looking at the year ahead, what is your expectation for the future condition of the labour market regarding net job creation and talent availability?



Source: Chief People Officers' Survey. (May 2026).

While the September 2025 edition[2] reflected short-term caution – with 42% of respondents predicting "no change" – this edition's responses reflect a more divided outlook among chief people officers regarding the year ahead (Figure 1).

Half of the surveyed chief people officers expect talent availability in their industry to improve over the next 12 months, while 21% foresee no change and 29% anticipate weakening conditions. Expectations around job creation are even more mixed in the eyes of chief people officers: 35% of respondents expect somewhat stronger job growth, while 43% anticipate somewhat weaker conditions and 21% expect no change.

This lack of consensus reflects ongoing uncertainty and diverging industrial and regional realities shaping labour market dynamics. Chief people officers consulted for this outlook emphasize that the core constraint is not overall labour supply, but access to high-skilled, future-ready talent.

> **The most acute issue is not talent supply; it is talent matching. Skills-based workforce strategies can help bridge that gap.**
>
> Chief people officer perspective

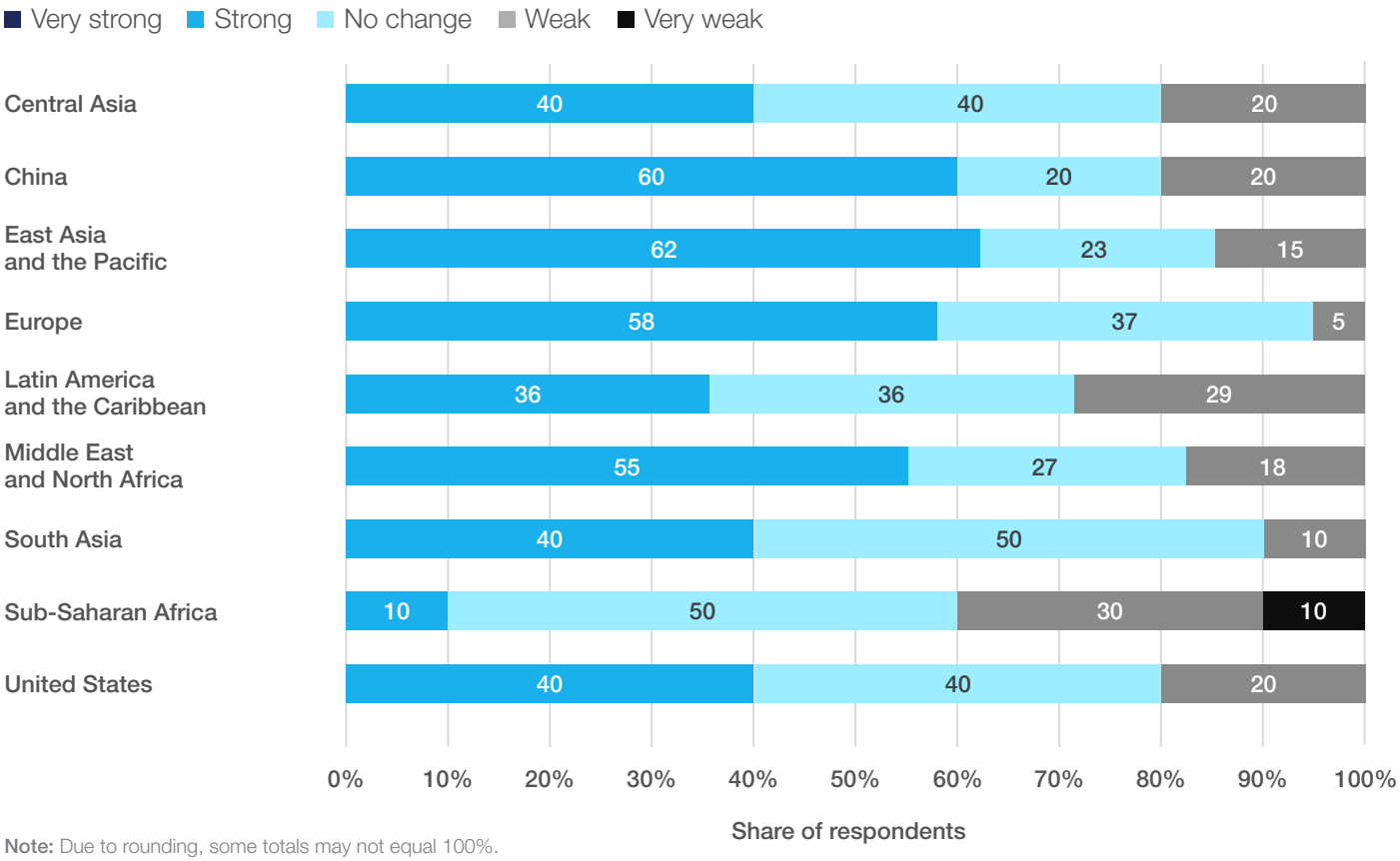


Regional 12-month talent trends

Chief people officers similarly assessed expected near-term talent availability across regions in which their organizations operate (Figure 2).

Figure 2

Looking at the year ahead, what is your expectation for the state of talent availability in the following regions?



Note: Due to rounding, some totals may not equal 100%.

Source: Chief People Officers' Survey. (May 2026).

The regional outlook shows some divergence. In East Asia and the Pacific, China and Europe, expectations of strong talent availability are comparatively higher than in other regions.

By contrast, Sub-Saharan Africa and parts of Latin America display relatively higher shares of weaker expectations, indicating more cautious sentiment in these markets, despite growing working-age populations. Other regions, including South Asia, the Middle East and North Africa, and Central Asia, reflect a more balanced distribution between strong and moderate expectations.

2 Workforce strategy trends

Workforce strategy focus areas in the year ahead

The Chief People Officers' Outlook surveys evolving workforce strategy priorities among people leaders. This edition revisited the same set of workforce strategy priorities surveyed in September 2025 to assess how workforce strategies are evolving over time (Table 1).

Table 1
Workforce strategy priorities, September 2025 vs. April 2026

	Workforce strategies prioritized by organizations for the year ahead in Q2/2025	Workforce strategies prioritized by organizations for the year ahead in Q1/2026
1	✓ Review organizational structure and job design	✓ Review organizational structure and job design
2	✓ Focus on workplace culture and articulating business purpose and impact	✓ Provide upskilling and reskilling programmes
3	✓ Support workforce deployment of AI and process automation	✓ Support workforce deployment of AI and process automation

The previous edition's results[3] highlighted organizational redesign, culture and AI deployment as leading priorities. This edition's findings point in a similar direction, with reviewing organizational structure and job design emerging as the top priority, selected by 74% of respondents.

The second most-frequently cited priorities – each identified by 70% of respondents – are providing upskilling and reskilling programmes and supporting the deployment of AI and process automation across the workforce.

Compared to September 2025, organizations' strategic direction remains consistent. Structural redesign and AI integration continue to anchor workforce strategy, while no major new priorities have emerged. Emphasis has shifted from broad transformation themes towards more targeted interventions, particularly reviewing job design and strengthening upskilling efforts to support technology adoption.

> **Mandatory AI training didn't stick. We had to make it real to the role. AI only scales when it is grounded in how people actually work, requiring a strategic look at workflows across the company.**
>
> Chief people officer perspective



Workforce deployment of AI

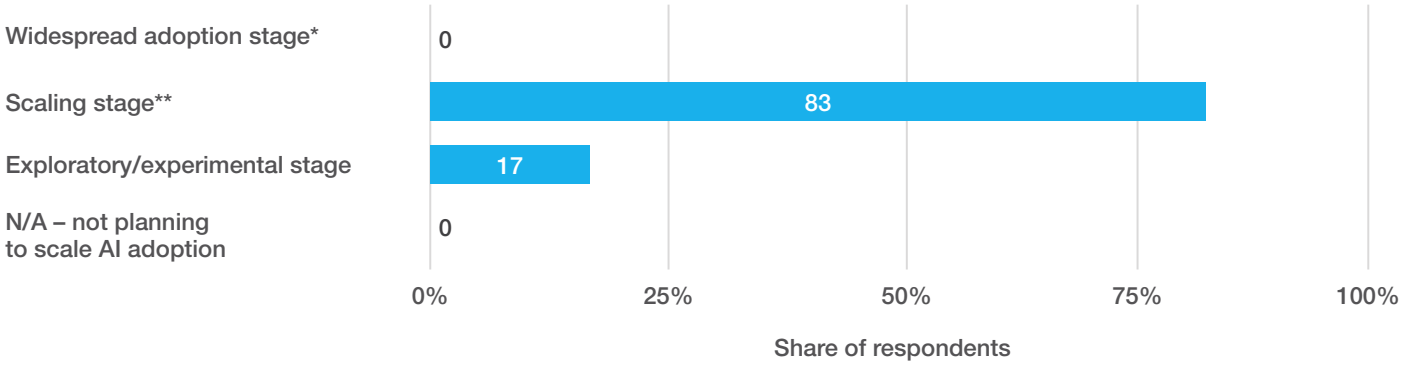
When asked to assess their organization's expected stage of adoption of AI and process automation over the next 6–12 months, most chief people officers expect to be in the scaling stage, where AI tools are being deployed across multiple use cases, functions or teams, with increasing integration into workforce processes. This marks a shift from intention to execution, suggesting that many organizations are now expecting to move beyond experimentation (Figure 3).

Conversely, 17% of respondents expect to remain in the exploratory or experimental phase, where initiatives are limited to pilots or proofs of concept with minimal enterprise-wide rollout.

While none of the chief people officers surveyed reported no further plans for scaling AI adoption, none yet perceived their organization to be at a widespread adoption stage either.

Figure 3

Chief people officers' assessment of their organization's stage of adoption of AI and process automation over the next 6–12 months



Notes: *AI is embedded at scale across the organization and systematically shapes workforce deployment, roles and processes; **AI tools are being deployed across multiple use cases, functions or teams, with increasing integration into workforce processes.

Source: Chief People Officers' Survey. (May 2026).

This evolution is particularly notable when viewed in light of the previous edition's findings. In mid-2025, chief people officers were primarily focused on laying the foundations for this transition. When asked to rank their priorities related to workforce deployment of AI and process automation technologies over the subsequent 6–12 months, over half of respondents ranked collaborating with technical departments in designing and deploying AI tools and policies among their top three priorities.[4]

The current results suggest that previous cross-functional collaborations are now translating into broader organizational rollout. Where earlier conversations often focused on broad scenarios and divergent expectations about the scale of AI disruption, discussions today are more grounded in operational realities and practical implementation.

Looking ahead, chief people officers are increasingly focused on ensuring that AI deployment translates into sustainable workforce outcomes. Consultations consistently emphasize that positive gains are conditional. They depend on changes in role design, performance management and talent processes. Earlier phases of adoption prioritized training and upskilling individuals. Attention is now shifting towards redesigning work itself.

> **Last year, we were still trying to understand what AI is. A year later, the conversation has shifted to what it means for our workforce. We haven't seen widespread changes to jobs yet – but those shifts are beginning to emerge.**
>
> Chief people officer perspective

3 Geopolitics meets the workplace

Workforce impact of geopolitical fragmentation

Geopolitical fragmentation and geoeconomic uncertainty are shaping the 2026 operating environment. The World Economic Forum's *Chief Economists' Outlook: January 2026* highlighted geopolitical tensions and trade investment disruption as elevated risks within the broader economic landscape, alongside public debt and stretched asset valuations.[5]

A key shift noted by chief people officers consulted for this outlook is that disruption from geoeconomics and geopolitics is no longer only confined to trade, technology and capital flows; it is directly impacting people mobility and workforce planning. Global competition for strategic skills – particularly in AI, advanced manufacturing and energy – is increasingly shaped by national policy and industrial strategy.[6]

> **Geopolitics used to be about trade flows and technology. Now access to people, talent and skills is becoming the next lever.**
>
> Chief people officer perspective

The Chief People Officers' Outlook survey – conducted in January and February 2026 – asked respondents which geoeconomic and geopolitical trends most directly affected their workforces (Figure 4). The most frequently cited measures with real workforce impacts include government labour-market interventions (e.g. localization quotas), followed by migration and visa restrictions. Recent research similarly highlights that cross-border talent mobility is becoming more constrained and politically mediated, reshaping global workforce models.[7]

Other notable trends highlighted by respondents include cyberthreats, industrial espionage, data breaches, competition in critical technologies, energy security and climate geopolitics, trade tensions and protectionist measures, regional instability and conflict, and supply chain realignment.

Figure 4
Top geopolitical and geoeconomic disruptions driving changes in workforce strategy

1. Government labour market interventions (e.g. localization quotas)
2. Migration and visa restrictions
3. Cyberthreats, industrial espionage, data breaches
4. Competition in critical technologies
5. Energy security and climate geopolitics
6. Trade tensions and protectionist measures
7. Regional instability or conflict
8. Supply chain realignment

Chief people officers surveyed for this edition were also asked how geopolitical developments are most directly affecting their organizations' workforce strategies. The factor most highly ranked by respondents was limiting access to international talent, followed by wage or cost pressures in certain regions, shifting demand for certain roles or skills across regions and requirements for strengthening governance.

Organizational responses and resilience strategies

Chief people officers surveyed for this outlook were asked which aspects of strategic workforce planning they will prioritize in the next 6–12 months in response to geoeconomic and geopolitical disruption.

In the near term, organizations are strengthening local talent pools through internal mobility and rapid redeployment capabilities – a priority for 50% of surveyed chief people officers. This is followed by enhancing cybersecurity and data protection, safeguarding sensitive roles and reviewing reward frameworks in light of regulatory and protectionist shifts (Figure 5).

> **We need to transform how we approach change and build agility into the organization. Change is part of the normal – not an emergency response.**
>
> Chief people officer perspective

Figure 5
Strategic workforce planning priorities in response to geoeconomic and geopolitical developments

1. **Enhancing internal mobility and rapid redeployment capabilities**
2. **Enhancing cybersecurity and data protection, and safeguarding sensitive workforce roles**
3. **Reviewing reward, pay and benefits frameworks to reflect regulatory and protectionist changes**
4. **Developing regional or diversified talent hubs to reduce geopolitical dependency**
5. **Conducting scenario planning and revisiting organizational structures for geopolitical resilience**

In practice, these priorities are translating into accelerated localization, targeted upskilling efforts to address regional skills shortages, and domestic capability-building aligned with critical national sectors through scholarships and traineeships.

In a fragmented and polarized global labour market marked by mismatches between where talent is located, where jobs are created and which skills are in demand,[8] resilience increasingly depends on geographic diversification, skills-based workforce planning and operating models capable of adapting to regulatory and geopolitical shocks. Strategic use of international mobility is becoming central to this approach.

Other priorities include renewed investment in leadership transformation and the scaling of continuous learning models. Lifelong learning platforms and internal mobility pathways are being integrated at scale, signalling a transition towards durable, skills-based workforce systems.

Together, these responses indicate that geoeconomic and geopolitical pressures are accelerating a structural shift: from firm-centric adjustments towards coordinated workforce ecosystems.

> **International mobility and diversified talent pools have become a resilience imperative, not a nice-to-have.**
>
> Chief people officer perspective

Conclusion

The geoeconomic and geopolitical challenges to talent strategy highlighted in this outlook cannot be solved through isolated corporate or policy interventions. Durable workforce resilience in a fragmented world will ultimately depend on coordinated ecosystem approaches rather than firm-level action alone.[9]

Consultations with chief people officers at large global employers further underline the importance of shifting from competition **for** talent to collaboration **on** talent. Leading employers are positioning themselves as long-term talent developers, investing in communities and national capabilities beyond their immediate business needs. Interviewees emphasized that reskilling efforts cannot be confined to the needs of a single company or industry; workforce development must serve the broader ecosystem.



Durable growth and resilience not only depend on attracting talent, but on collectively building and mobilizing it across sectors and geographies. Global collaboration – across governments, academia and industry – is essential to meet future talent needs.

Chief people officer perspective

If geopolitical fragmentation risks dividing labour markets, collaboration must reconnect them. The task ahead is not simply to manage disruption, but to build more resilient and durable jobs and talent ecosystems – enabling inclusive opportunity and supporting shared prosperity.

Contributors

The World Economic Forum would like to thank the members of the Community of Chief People Officers for their thought leadership and guidance. We also thank the members of the broader core community of the Centre for the New Economy and Society's Future of Jobs Initiative for their ongoing commitment and contributions to addressing several of the factors presented in this outlook.

We would like to thank, in particular, all community members who completed the Chief People Officers' Outlook survey and contributed to this edition of the outlook through community discussions and thematic consultations. We would like to extend particular thanks to people leaders from Allianz, Cisco Systems, Merck, PwC, Saudi Aramco and Siemens for their time and insight during individual consultations.

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The views expressed in this briefing do not necessarily represent the views of the World Economic Forum or those of its members and partners. This briefing is a contribution to the World Economic Forum's insight and interaction activities and is published to elicit comments and further debate.

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